new script for use in the multilingual empire, as an alternative to the Chinese script based on ideograms and the Uighur alphabet which had hitherto been used as a script for the Mongolian language. Phags-pa created a new script based on his native Tibetan alphabet and this was used for some time for official communications in the empire. However, it never came into general use and slowly died out.

Kublai and his successors continued with the Song policy of encouraging maritime trade and maintained a strong navy, introducing some innovations of their own. Astronomy in particular witnessed major advances through Persian astronomers invited to the Mongol court. The Persian astronomer Jamal al-din helped set up an astronomical observatory in the capital. Persia was also the source of medicinal sciences, and an Office of Muslim Medicine was set up to collect and collate medicinal herbs and practices derived from Persia.

This is the time when China began importing cobalt from Persia for use in its porcelain industry, creating the blue-and-white ceramics which are famous across the world as Ming blue-and-white, but actually belong to an earlier age. Persian miniature painting had an influence on Yuan painting, just as the Chinese motifs of the dragon and phoenix began to appear in Persian art.

Despite the tensions and occasional clashes between the Yuan rulers in China and the Chagatai Mongols who controlled the Central Asian caravan routes, India–China trade and travel through the oasis towns and Afghanistan may have continued, but with interruptions. The nature and extent of this trade are not well documented. We know that the caravan routes to Persia and West Asia over land and on to the eastern Mediterranean by sea were in use during this period. What is better known, however, is that the Yuan dynasty maintained maritime trade relations with the Malabar and Coromandel coasts of southern India. In Chapter 6, we referred to Ibn Battuta’s account of Chinese ships visiting Calicut and Quilon (Kollam) regularly. Here is his full description of various types of Chinese ships in the Calicut harbour in the 1340s:

. . . the greatest is called a junk, the middling sized a zaw, the least a kakam. The sails of these